

The easiest way for a baby to be born is head down with the back of the baby's head (occiput) and spine facing toward the front (anterior) of your uterus, known as an occiput anterior position (OA).

Your baby can also be born vaginally from an occiput posterior position (OP; back of baby's head and spine face toward the back of your uterus), but this can take longer and be more painful. Vaginal tears are more common when babies are born in the occiput posterior position.

A final position is when your baby faces your side, known as occiput transverse. Full-term babies can't be born in the transverse position since the head is too big to fit this way. However it's usual for babies to rotate around during labor, although this would need to happen before you start to push. If this doesn't happen, labor may need to be assisted (see [Assisted birth](#)).

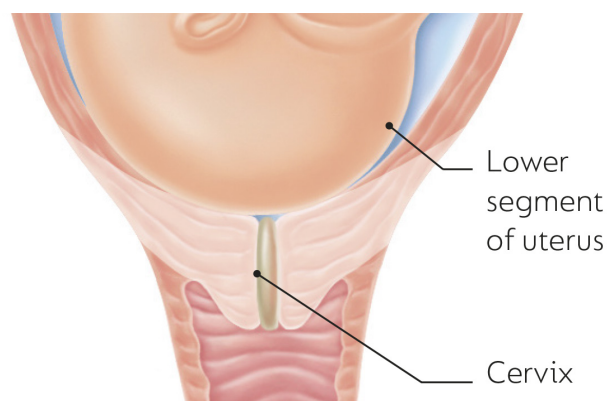
Descent with contractions Although most of the time your doctor will try to examine you between contractions, sometimes it helps to see how much the baby's head comes down in the pelvis during a contraction, referred to as the descent. If there is a good descent, it means that the baby is fitting well into your pelvis and that your contractions are effective.

CHANGES TO THE CERVIX

The cervix is comprised of firm muscle that forms a strong base at the bottom of the uterus.

For your baby to be born, the cervix needs to shorten and soften so that it can open, or dilate, and your baby can pass out of the uterus and into the vagina.

Toward the end of pregnancy, substances in your blood called prostaglandins start to soften the cervix so that it becomes more malleable. While you are pregnant, your cervix is usually around 2 to 3 cm long. In late pregnancy or early labor, contractions start to shorten the cervix, a process known as effacement. Most women have a cervix that has shortened to 1 cm during the very early stages of labor. This is also referred to as 50 percent effaced. As the cervix continues to shorten, the cervix is gradually drawn up by the uterus, and by the time it is 100 percent effaced, the cervix will have started to open. Eventually the cervix becomes fully dilated (see [Dilation](#)), and the baby can be pushed out.



As labor approaches, the cervix starts to lose its firmness and starts to soften in response to the presence of prostaglandins in the blood and contractions.